

5 LESSONS FROM \$5M+ IN EMAIL REVENUE

Wil Cleaveland



Who's Telling You This?

I'm Wil. Over the past decade I've written and deployed thousands of emails as the copy chief for DTC ecommerce brands – \$10M+ in tracked funnel revenue, with email programs holding \$50K+/week for years at a stretch, plus an SMS program I built from zero to \$20K+/week.

"As a guy who built an affiliate company, solely through email, from \$0 to \$300,000 every month – if I could choose 1 guy to do it again with from scratch, I'd choose Wil."

– Lou Cozzolino

A lot of these lessons I had to learn the hard way...

This brief guide is to help ensure YOU don't have to do that. :)

So let's jump right in...

#1 – Every Email You Write Should Be Centered Around ONE Angle/Big Idea

Most marketers probably have a stronger focus muscle than the average person.

So they wrongly assume readers can juggle multiple ideas to piece together what you're saying.

They write like they're Matt Damon scratching on a chalkboard in *Good Will Hunting*.

Big mistake. :/

Instead, assume your reader barely has enough headspace to focus on just one thing – because that's the reality.

Your email is *competing for attention with tons of other things* inside the reader's head.

So once you have their attention, lock down like a vice grip and don't let go!

For example... say you're selling a fitness smartwatch.

There are loads and loads of reasons for people to want one:

- It tracks sleep, heart rate, and recovery automatically.
- The battery lasts two weeks, not two days.
- It's waterproof enough for the pool.
- It costs less than one month with a personal trainer.
- It can catch heart-rhythm problems early.
- It looks like a normal watch in a meeting.

Now, an amateur copywriter would think... *WOW, look at all these benefits I can front-load into my email!!*

But that won't work.

You **MUST** center your subject line and lead around just one of these to craft your angle/big idea.

Then spend the first 3-4 lines of body copy to further dimensionalize it.

Of course, you can highlight these additional benefits in bullets toward the bottom of your email.

But the spirit of the whole email needs to be firmly grounded in a singular angle/big idea – or else it'll flop.

#2 – Always “Echo” Your Subject Line in the First Line of Body Copy

This is a simple nugget I guarantee will improve your email performance if you aren't doing it already.

Inject your subject line into the very first line of body copy of your email.

Easy peasy.

The rationale here is pretty obvious, but most people never think about it.

If your subject line's job is to get opens...

The job of your first line of body copy is to make them keep reading!

Your subject line is like a promise.

And if you don't fulfill that promise right away in your body copy, people are going to fall off.

Here's what that looks like in practice, with a subject line of *"The 60-second fix for terrible sleep"*:

WEAK first line: "Hope your week is going great!"

STRONG first line: "Here's the 60-second fix for the worst night of sleep you keep having on Sundays."

Same subject line. One email keeps its promise immediately – the other breaks it.

#3 – Stop "Throat Clearing" In Your Leads

This is the biggest issue I see from inexperienced copywriters.

Even if they're writing off a solid angle/big idea... they waste too much time "throat clearing" in the lead, *and totally lose the reader's attention.*

As a rudimentary example... say we're writing an email for a fat-loss supplement...

A lot of copywriters might start the email like this:

"Everybody knows how hard it is to lose weight. You eat salads for dinner five times per week... you spend hours on the stair-climber... but nothing ever changes.

It's so frustrating.

And it feels unfair too... you see other people put in the work and get results... so why not you?"

That's what throat clearing looks like – saying extraneous things people already know, and that do nothing to pull readers into the email.

Instead... you could replace all that copy with this ONE LINE:

"In 2 seconds, you're going to see the #1 clinically-backed weight loss solution for everyone who's wasted years on diet and exercise with nothing to show for it."

#4 – Don't Be Clever & "Kill Your Darlings"

Copywriting isn't stand-up comedy.

Sure, you might entertain a bit naturally if you're in-tune with your audience, but we're writing to earn sales... not chuckles.

Follow Stephen King's advice, and "kill your darlings."

If you write something and think to yourself... *damn that's clever.*

It's probably weighing down your copy and distracting from the offer.

So kill it! 

Here's the test: delete the clever line. If the email loses selling power, keep it. If it only loses entertainment... it was a darling.

#5 – Burn Your Thesaurus

Even if you're writing for a more sophisticated audience, the simple truth is you're not writing to other copy nerds.

You're writing to regular people – and regular people don't like thinking too much.

So don't make them think!!

If you can't make your point without using five dollar words, you're a bad copywriter.

There's never a situation where you can't convert verbose copy into simpler terms... and it will always come out stronger for it.

For example, selling a knife sharpener:

WEAK: "Experience unparalleled culinary precision through our proprietary honing geometry."

STRONG: "Twenty seconds a side. Your knife shaves paper again."

Ready for More?

Everything I write starts with these five rules. If this helped:

- **See the receipts** – work samples, testimonials, and my full resume live at <https://wilcleave.land>
- **Want this applied to your list?** Grab a call slot: calendly.com/wccleaveland
- **Building an email program in-house?** I take full-time roles too. Resume's on the site.

Cheers to more sales!

- Wil